

Chapter 7 – Greenways

Monroe County's linkages for a "Green Infrastructure"

Greenways are connecting corridors that help preserve and maintain both the fabric of our natural resource base and the fabric of our communities. Greenways ensure that both human and wildlife interactions can be pursued without the imposition of a scale of development that is more oriented to the automobile. As can be seen in the previous chapters, Monroe County is blessed with a great deal of natural diversity. Identifying and preserving greenways offers an important means to preserve and enhance that diversity. Meaningful corridors maintain important habitat linkages and preserve the green fabric so important to Monroe County's past, present, and future. Their definition and development will ensure this identity for future generations. Defining greenways now will also ensure an economic future related to this heritage.

Greenways provide a means to re-develop areas that have been degraded by development and to restore the green connections that have been lost. They also offer opportunities to celebrate the County's unique cultural heritage and to tie communities together through a "green infrastructure" rather than just a gray infrastructure of highways and roads oriented to the automobile.

Perhaps more than any other action, developing a greenway system has the potential to protect the quality of life and resources of the County.

As seen in Chapter 4 above, an important means to develop a greenway system can be part and parcel of the development process. It is not necessary to only acquire greenway corridors by fee. Designating and incorporating greenway principals in municipal codes through the *Growing Greener* program can be a major way to implement a greenway system.

The term "greenway" has received general usage only in relatively recent times. The concept, however, has been around for most of the last century. The Pennsylvania Greenway Partnership Commission has developed a working definition as highlighted below:

Greenway

“A greenway is a corridor of open space. Greenways vary greatly in scale, from narrow ribbons of green that run through urban, suburban, and rural areas to wide corridors that incorporate diverse natural, cultural, and scenic features. Greenways can be land- or water-based, running along stream corridors, shorelines, or wetlands. Some follow old railways, canals, ridgetops, or other features. They can incorporate both public and private property. Some greenways are primarily recreational corridors, while others function almost exclusively for environmental protection and are not designed for human passage. Greenways differ in their location and function, but overall, a greenway network will protect natural, cultural, and scenic resources, provide recreational benefits, enhance the natural beauty and the quality of life in neighborhoods and communities, and stimulate economic development opportunities.”

This is an appropriate working definition for Monroe County. An abbreviated form of this definition was used in the survey conducted as part of the *Greenway Project Feasibility Study* that preceded this plan (see Chapter 1 above).

Greenway opportunities in Monroe County include vast natural areas components, such as stream corridors, and natural areas and cultural features such as historic and abandoned rail corridors and utility right of ways. When tied together, these components can create a green infrastructure system that maintains and enriches the quality of life in Monroe County. This chapter focuses on the opportunities present in Monroe County and recommends ways for the County to seize these opportunities and advance their development through a set of working priorities. This chapter is meant to serve as a guide for the County’s municipalities so they may further define, explore, and ultimately help implement the countywide greenway system in collaboration with adjacent municipalities, private partners, and the County. This chapter also provides reference to the County’s model greenway effort as put forth in the *Greenway Project Feasibility Study* that should serve as a local demonstration of greenway benefits and of the partnership-building required to build and to maintain greenway initiatives.

Brief History of the Greenway Movement

This short history is offered to provide a perspective of the greenway movement over the last century. Greenways are enduring, and those with the foresight to create them will have served generations who will be eternally grateful.

In addition to New York’s Central Park, landscape architect Fredrick Law Olmstead also provided one of the country’s first greenways, Boston’s “Emerald Necklace.” This interconnected system of parks defines Boston for many and was originally proposed in 1887.

Closer to home, Benton McKay was largely responsible in the 1920s for the creation of the Appalachian Trail, which runs along Monroe County’s eastern border. Congress recently designated the Appalachian Trail as one of sixteen National Millennium Trails. Millennium Trails receive a White House Millennium Council

logo, have a map and description in the new National Trails website, were honored in a national event on National Trails Day 2000, and benefit from increased recognition through enhanced media visibility and special partnership and funding opportunities.

In the 1980s, two important events in the greenway movement were the founding of the Rails-to-Trails Conservancy (RTC), and the identification of visions and actions by the Presidents Commission on Americans Outdoors:

- Identify and protect important natural, recreational, and cultural resources;
- Take a more active role in planning where growth should and should not occur; and
- Use urban greenways to link both man-made and natural environments while providing close-to-home recreational opportunities for urban dwelling Americans.

In the 1990s, Charles E. Little in his defining book on the subject, *Greenways for America*, credits Edmund Bacon with first coining the term “greenway.” Bacon proposed a greenway plan for an undeveloped semi-rural area of northeast Philadelphia which “laid down the basic open space pattern before the developers got there.”

In Pennsylvania, the *Governor’s Conference on Greenways and Trails*, held April 27 through April 29, 1997, marked a milestone for the support and development of greenways and trails in Pennsylvania.

In June of 1999, the second *International Conference on Greenways and Trails* in Pittsburgh further marked the strong support of the movement in Pennsylvania. There were nearly 900 registrants and 40 international guests from 18 different countries attending the conference. The event brought additional resources and attention to the state and its trails and greenways system.

In Monroe County, the 2020 planning process saw the importance of preserving a “green infrastructure” through the use of greenways and trails. The County commissioned a study of an important potential greenway corridor in one of the most urbanizing sections of the County. This corridor has potential ties to five Monroe municipalities. The *Monroe Greenway Project Feasibility Study* is by reference a component of this *Monroe County Open Space Plan* (see *Appendix A* for an Executive Summary of this report.)

Economic Benefits of Greenways

In addition to the benefits described above, The Rivers, Trails and Conservation Assistance Program of the National Park Service published an important resource book that examined the economic impacts of protecting rivers, trails, and greenway corridors.⁵ While noting that detailed economic studies may require the services of a

⁵ Economic Impact of Protecting Rivers, Trails and Greenway Corridors, National Park Service, Rivers, Trails and Conservation Assistance, Program, 1995.

trained economist, the resource provides concepts and strategies that can produce positive economic impacts in the following sectors for communities that implement a greenways and trails program:

- Real property values;
- Expenditures by residents;
- Commercial uses;
- Tourism;
- Corporate relocation and retention; and
- Public cost reduction.

In summary, this resource provides strong support for the two pillars of the Monroe 2020 Plan: open space protection, conservation, and enhancement; and economic development. Both can be achieved through a program and system that attends to the County's "green infrastructure."

Countywide Greenway System

Introduction

The greenway system component of the County's Open Space Plan is what ties the other system components together to create the green infrastructure referred to above. A countywide regional system of greenways needs to be created to form the skeleton of an even larger greenway system. The larger system will be filled out by additional greenway connections put forth by municipal, inter-municipal and private non-profit groups to complete the vision of Monroe' green infrastructure and the vision of Monroe as *Forever Green*. Also, local non-profit conservation groups should be encouraged to take a stewardship role in the creation, operation, and management of the countywide greenway system. The *Growing Greener* program outlined in Chapter 4 of this plan offers a way to acquire and preserve these greenway corridors on a site-by-site basis as part of the development process.

The identification of a basic countywide regional greenway system was guided by objectives expressed through the public involvement process. These include:

- The regional system should be distributed fairly throughout the County;
- The majority of existing public and privately protected lands should be connected by greenways with trails;
- The system should serve conservation functions and especially help protect the County's water resources;
- The system should provide multiple functions as much as possible; and

- The system should compliment and extend existing trails and greenways.

Greenway System Concept

The countywide greenway system is composed of two major components that must be examined in order to identify potential greenway corridors in Monroe County. First, there are resource areas having inherent qualities that make them appropriate as destinations or as starting points. We will refer to them as the “nodes” and “hubs” of the potential greenway system. Second, the distinguishing feature of greenways is that they provide connections or “links.” Therefore, in order to identify potential greenway corridors in Monroe County, it is helpful to first understand what potential resources and sites serve these functions.

The anatomy of a greenway system in Monroe County would be composed of these hubs, nodes, and linkages. Potential greenway hubs and nodes in the County include urban centers, major subdivisions, villages, and hamlets where many of Monroe County’s citizens live. Potential hubs may also include school sites, parks, state game lands, trailheads to natural areas, resort sites, and shopping centers.

Potential linkages in the County’s greenway system include river corridors, rail corridors, utility corridors, and sensitive habitat corridors. It is important to note, however, that while greenways with trails are popular, greenways without trails are also important. In some cases, a trail system will avoid sensitive habitat areas or private lands along a greenway and make trail connections around these features, while some greenways may have no trails at all. Other linkages include trails along scenic or landscaped roadways.

While greenways vary widely in size, the greenway corridor itself is primarily a linear feature. These corridors provide the “linkage” function of a greenway system. Individual greenway corridors may function differently, but each serves the important purpose of providing connections. Six forms identified in the Pennsylvania Greenways and Trails How-To Manual⁶ include:

1. Conservation greenways;
2. Recreational greenways;
3. Riparian buffers;
4. Landscape corridors;
5. Greenbelts; and
6. Natural areas.

The countywide greenway system will reflect a combination of most of these forms.

⁶Creating Connections – The Pennsylvania Greenways and Trails How-To Manual, Pennsylvania Greenways Partnership, 1998.

Methodology

The methodology of this plan is aimed at identifying “conceptual” greenways, which can be used to identify major greenway spines that are distributed across the County. These conceptual greenways differ from greenway master plans that identify specific beginning and end points, specific routes, ownership, and management and operations plans. Rather, the conceptual greenways have been defined in this report as a means to focus the additional planning required to realize their creation. A three-step process was used to identify the potential countywide greenway system, which would form the basis of a green infrastructure spine as put forward in the County Comprehensive Plan. These steps include:

1. Inventory resources influencing the creation of greenways;
 - A. Inventory potential hubs and nodes including natural, historic/cultural, and community features that are potential destinations/resources along a greenway adding to their value; and
 - B. Inventory potential linkage corridors including environmental and man-made linear resources influencing the creation of a greenway.
2. Inventory existing regional and inter-municipal greenways; and
3. Identify potential priority greenway corridors based on the inventoried information in Steps 1 and 2.

Step 1 – Inventory of Features Influencing Greenway System Development

Step 1A – Inventory Greenway Hubs and Nodes

These are the resources and sites to which the greenway system is secured. They provide the origination and destinations for the movement of people and wildlife along the narrower linkage corridors or links of the greenway system. In Monroe County, one of these sites may be as large as a 2,000-acre state game land or as small as a municipal park of a few acres. The following resources provide potential hubs and nodes for linkage:

Parks & Public Lands

Approximately 20% of Monroe County’s lands are publicly protected. These lands serve diverse conservation and recreation purposes. The State Game Lands Commission manages the largest segment of these lands, approximately 38,000 acres. Pennsylvania State Parks and Forestry manages another 17,241 acres and the National Park Service manages approximately 5,975 acres. Another approximate 2,000 acres is protected as purchased agricultural easements. Municipal park authorities manage approximately 500 acres while roughly 120 acres is protected under the County-owned Kettle Creek Wildlife Sanctuary. The Bethlehem Pennsylvania Water Authority manages approximately 10,798 acres, although these lands may be more vulnerable to disposal than the others mentioned above. The distribution of these resources is illustrated in *Figure 7.1 – Parks & Public Lands*. The large tracts of federal and state lands plus lands owned by the Bethlehem Water

Authority are defining features of public open space in Monroe County. It is because of these players and the open space framework formed by their lands that Monroe County can strive to be *Forever Green*. While County and municipal acquisitions are central to the Open Space Plan; they will provide less land area than has already been secured by these entities. Therefore, for a system of greenways connecting these resources as a whole to work in the long run, a formal coordinating mechanism needs to be created. The County needs to take the lead in establishing this mechanism. Quarterly meetings among principals to review open space policy and operations should be established and promoted.

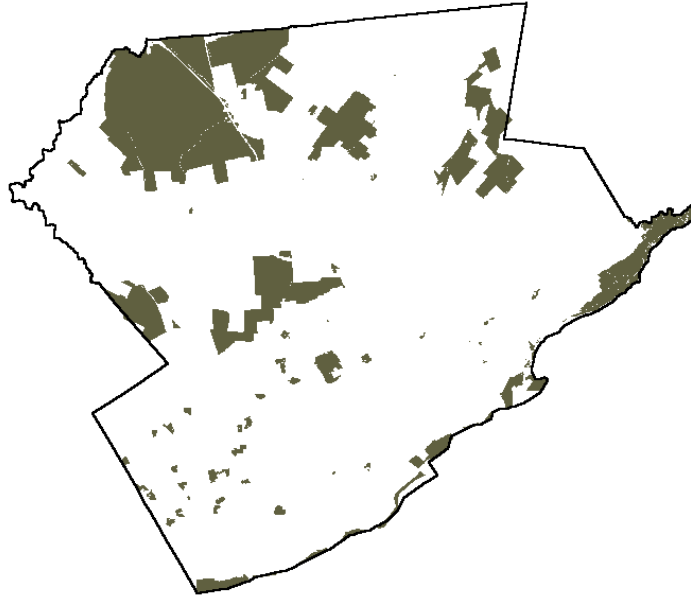


Figure 7.1 – Parks & Public Lands (dark areas)

Private Conservation Lands

Lands protected by conservancies and trusts amount to approximately 5,400 acres. Other major private landowners include Monroe County's many resorts, Boy and Girl Scout camps, and camps managed by other private organizations. These lands often occupy some of Monroe County's most scenic and resource-rich areas. These organizations often have an interest in protecting the resource for wildlife habitat and in providing educational and interpretive opportunities. They may also be open to providing shared public use for recreational trails. Close to 17,000 acres are owned and managed by these major landholders. The former group of properties is protected in perpetuity, while the latter group is subject to development pressure and economic constraints and cannot be viewed as protected, although many may be seen as quasi-protected. The distribution of these resources is illustrated in *Figure 7.2 – Private Conservation Lands*. Owners and principals of this group of landowners should also participate in the organizing mechanism suggested above.

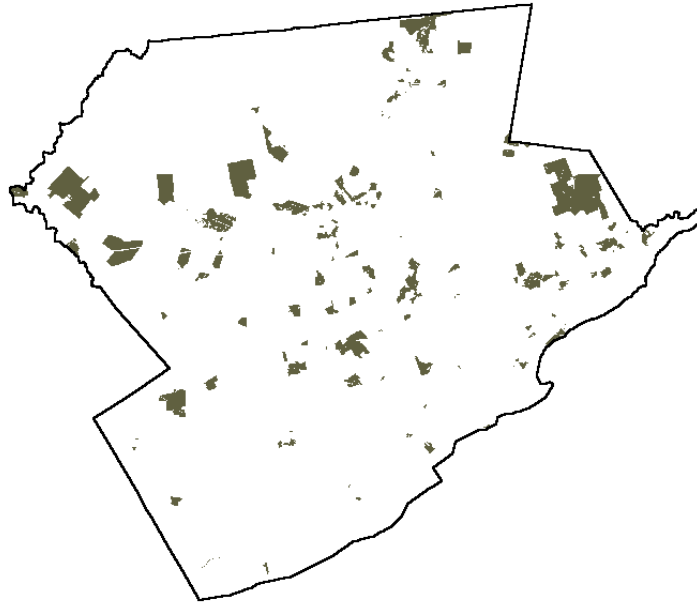


Figure 7.2 – Private Conservation Lands (dark areas)

Important Natural Area Sites

Chapter 3 dealt extensively with this component. The County's Natural Areas Inventory identifies many important sites based on biodiversity and species rarity. See *Figure 3.1 – Natural Areas Inventory* above.

Using criteria and methods explained in Chapter 3 above, important natural areas were mapped based on additional natural areas criteria. This mapping effort used available GIS data sets and a cartographic modeling tool. *Figure 3.7 – Important Natural Areas* illustrates the result of this effort. Important natural sites are also addressed in Chapter 4. The map of *Potential Conservation Lands* referenced in this chapter is a first-cut map on a countywide basis that identifies primary and secondary conservation areas and is an initial step to identifying these locations at the local municipal level. *Figure 4.2 – Local Green Infrastructure/Potential Conservation Lands* provides a sample of the mapping that should be done at the municipal level.

Historic & Cultural Sites

Monroe County's historic legacy is well documented in a report bearing the same name.⁷ The report provides a summary of historic sites and structures in the County and was designed to be used as a tool for the understanding, appreciation, and preservation of these sites and structures. Sites include:

- Pennsylvania Registry of Historic Places;

⁷ Monroe County – Historic Legacy, prepared by the Monroe County Planning Commission, April, 1980.

- Private structures;
- Resorts and hotels;
- Early industrial sites and structures; and
- Churches, schools, and public buildings.

In terms of greenway planning, these resources may be utilized to help interpret and protect history and heritage, offer recreational opportunities, and also serve as tourist destinations (refer to *Figure 7.4- Historic Sites*).

One structure that formerly dotted the countryside was Monroe County's picturesque covered bridge. While none remain today, in some cases evidence can still be seen. These sites could be interpreted and the bridges restored to aid in interpretation. The covered bridges are not mentioned in the legacy report but were noted and identified through the public involvement process.

In addition to the sites mapped above, the sites of Monroe County's covered bridges may also offer an opportunity to interpret and recognize the historic legacy. These sites were added to the GIS database and their locations are shown in *Figure 7.3 – Covered Bridge Sites*.

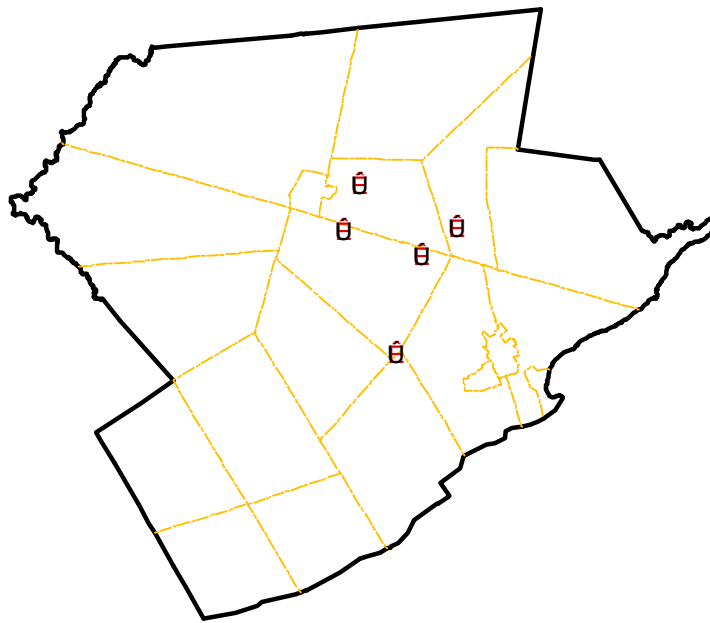
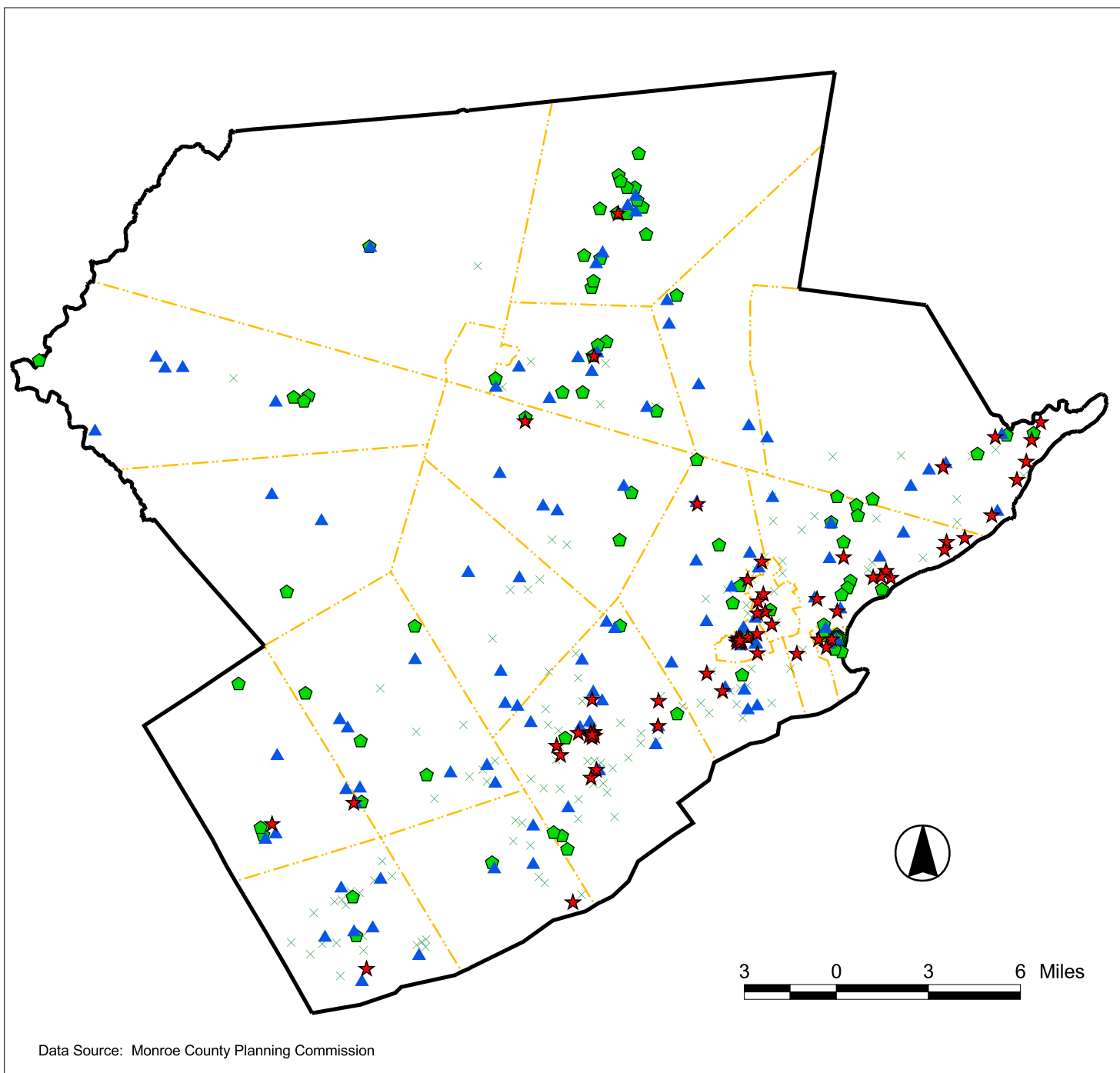


Figure 7.3 – Covered Bridge Sites (star points)

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County Open Space Plan

Monroe County, Pennsylvania



Map Legend

- | | | | |
|---|------------------------|-----------|--------------------|
| ★ | National Registry Site | × | Private Structure |
| ⬡ | Resorts | — — — — — | Municipal Boundary |
| ▲ | Public Structure | | |

Historic Sites

Figure 7.4

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Other historic landscapes in addition to those identified in Figure 3.11 are not well documented in any single source. However, the County's landscape played an important role in Native American life and the lives of early colonialists. Also, landscapes associated with the early industries were important in serving nearby urban centers, particularly the County's ice industry and resorts. These landscapes should be documented in subsequent plans by the municipalities and should also be incorporated into planning the greenway system for the County.

Centers of Community

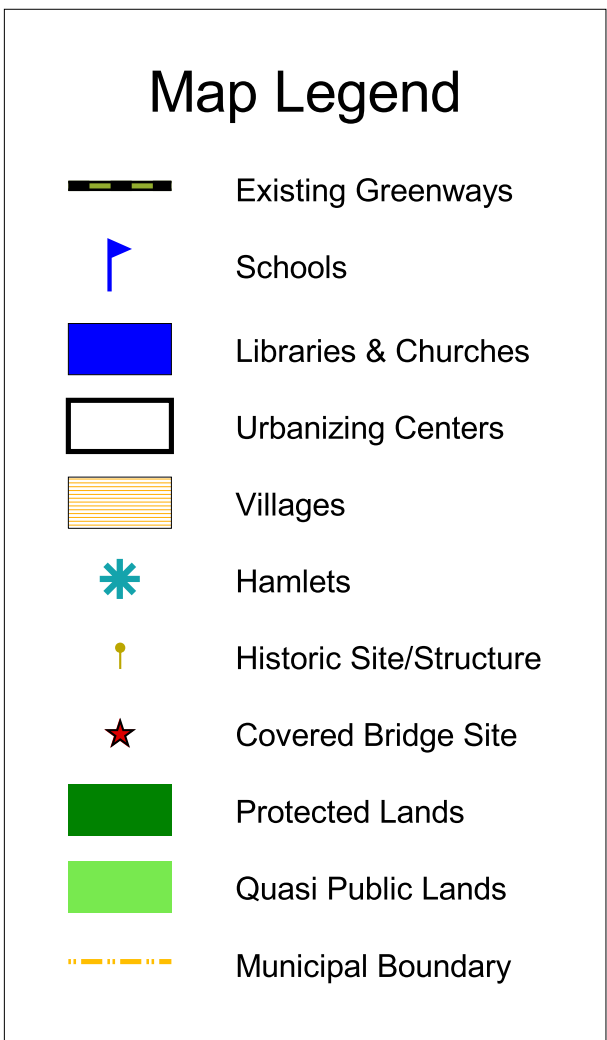
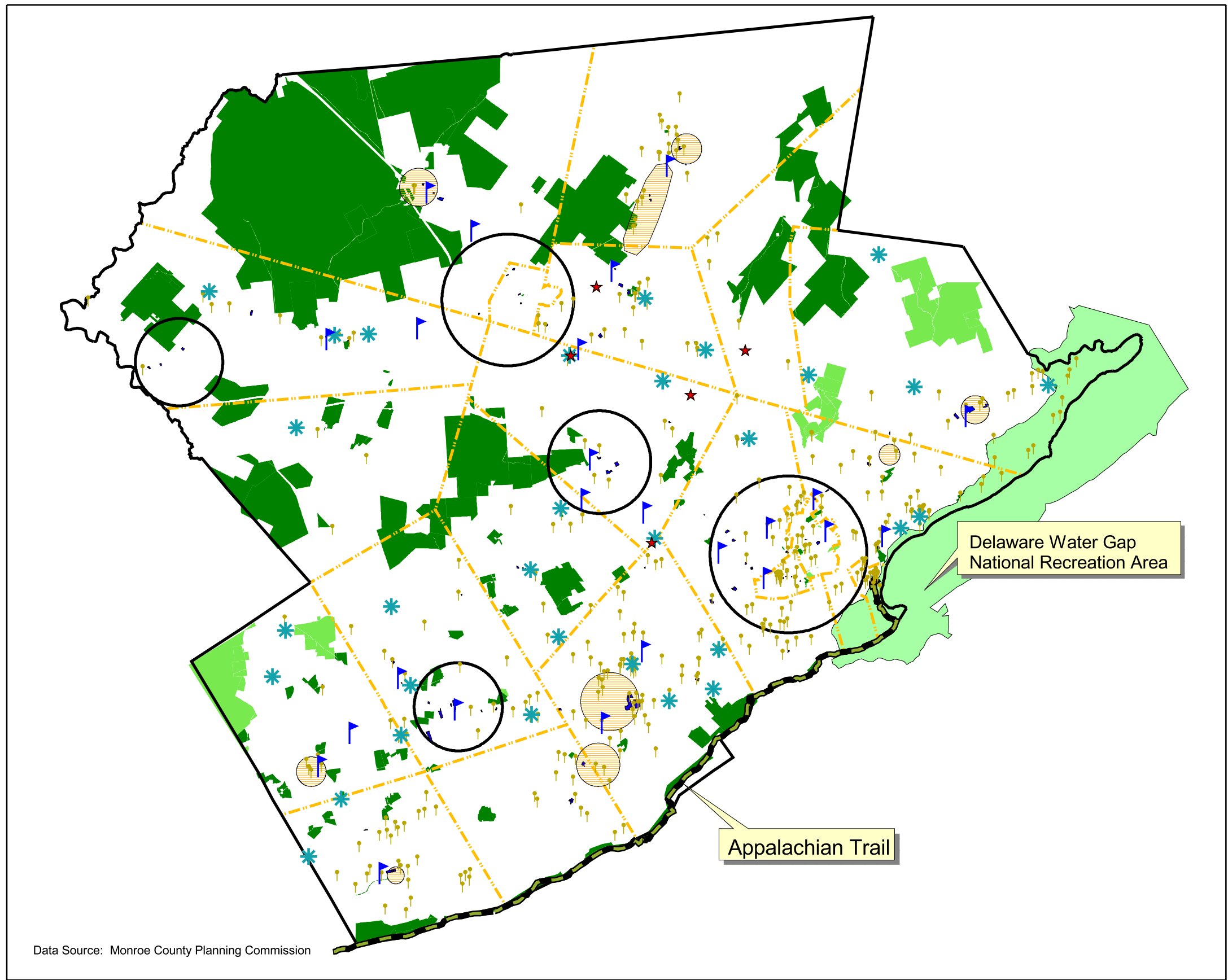
Centers of community are important areas of human gathering and are where major nodes to the greenway system should be located. Existing towns and villages, schools, libraries, shops, churches, work places, theatres, movie theaters, and restaurants all provide locations for human gathering. Also, two principal consensus recommendations from the Monroe 2020 Plan suggest the creation of more such places in the County:

- Create more gathering places for community activities; and
- Maintain and enhance the school system as an organizing element and a focus for community activity.

Greenways and trails can be an important means to achieve these ends.

Centers of community are identified in the composite mapping of all of these resources as illustrated by *Figure 7.5 – Potential Hubs & Nodes*. This then lays out the basic system for connecting the dots via green linkage corridors.

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County Open Space Plan
Monroe County, Pennsylvania

Potential Hubs & Nodes

Figure - 7.5



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Step 1B - Potential Linkage Corridors

Stream Corridors

Stream corridors are one of Monroe County's best assets, the majority of which are classified by the Pennsylvania Department of Environmental Protection as High Quality Cold Water Fisheries. Several are even classified as Exceptional Value in terms of water quality. The challenge for Monroe County is not to lose or degrade this resource. Many recent development projects ignore the value of stream corridors and the impact that their development poses. Recognizing greenway opportunities in the early planning of these projects can help build a greenway system, protect stream resources, and provide positive results for local citizens and the developer.

While many stretches of stream corridor are currently protected through ownership by fishing and hunting clubs, there are no assurances that they will continue to serve this stewardship role, and public access is often limited in these reaches. Apart from the Delaware Water Gap National Recreation Area, few existing parks or greenways currently protect Monroe's stream corridors. However, recent efforts of municipalities studied in the Monroe County *Greenway Project Feasibility Study* have begun to take on a stewardship role and to plan for greenways and trails within and among their communities.

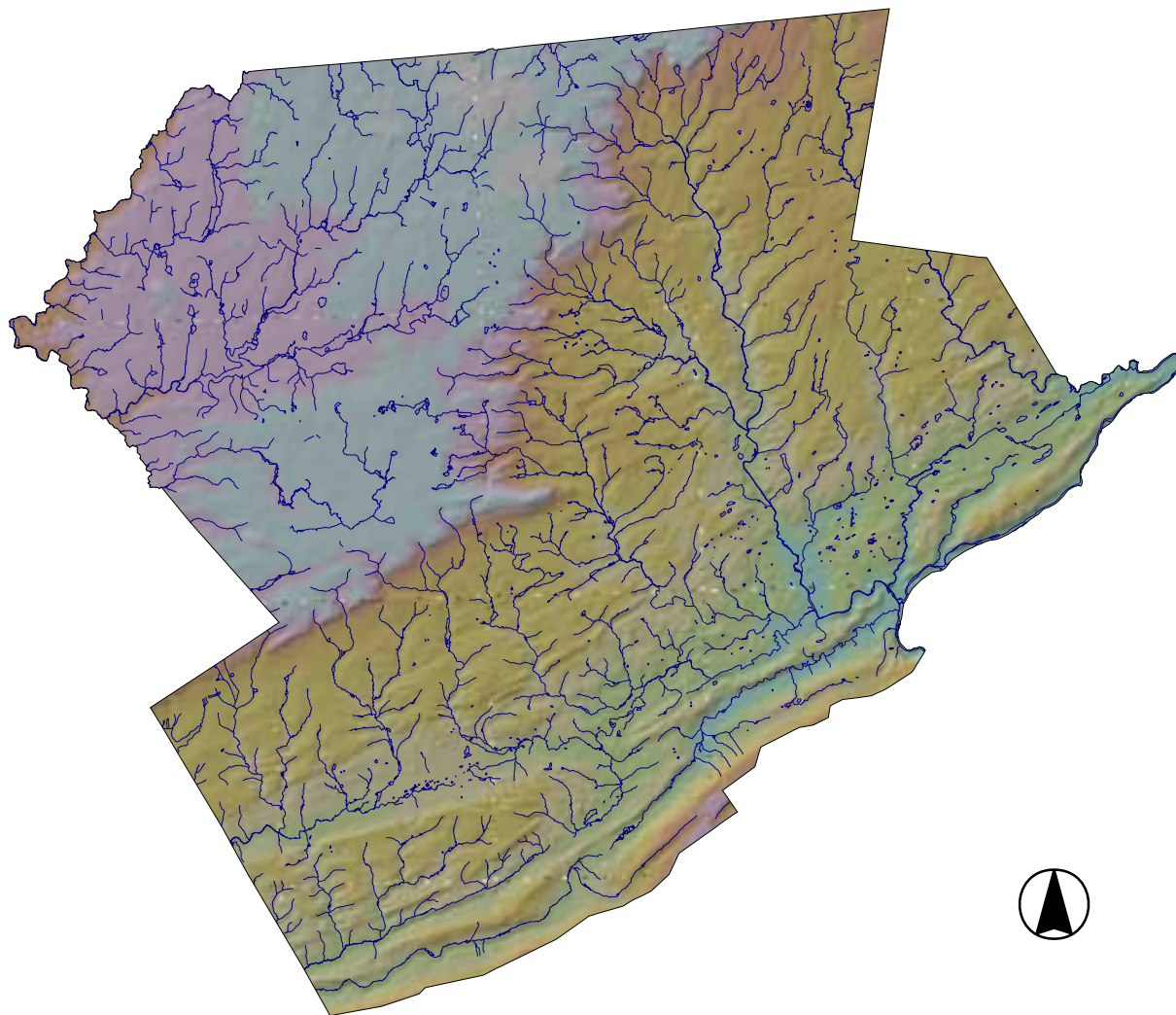
Given the strong desire among the OSAB for the protection of riparian corridors, a 150-foot buffer along both sides of the County's streams should be a primary identifier of linear greenway elements and of the vision put forth in this plan for the County greenway system.

Another natural linear feature in the County is ridgelines. In Monroe County these run primarily in a southwest to northeast direction. Locations of these two natural linear features are illustrated in *Figure 7.6 – Natural Linear Corridors*.

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County Open Space Plan

Monroe County, Pennsylvania



3 0 3 6 Miles

Data Source: Monroe County Planning Commission
& USGS Digital Elevation Grid

Map Legend

— Stream Corridors
Topographic relief showing ridge lines
with a stream corridor overlay.

Natural Linear Corridors

Figure - 7.6

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Railroad Corridors

As the most active part of the greenway movement today, the rails-to-trails phenomenon is growing in all 50 states, as well as in twenty foreign countries. This fact was reinforced in the summer of 1999 when Pennsylvania was host to the 2nd International Trails and Greenways Conference in Pittsburgh. One major highlight of the conference was the White House's Millennium Trails Program, which is championed by the first lady and has helped put trails into the mainstream of America's vision for the future.

Since its creation in 1986, the Rails-to-Trails Conservancy (RTC) has led this effort through the creation of needed federal policy changes in Washington, DC and the technical assistance to thousands of projects. Having created and maintained the environment for rail-trail growth, RTC now counts 1,036 open rail-trails totaling 10,937 miles with another 1,257 projects under development.

No state has had as much to gain or lose as Pennsylvania. While economic hard times and the federal funding of highways brought about the decline of the railroads, our rich railroad heritage left the Commonwealth with a vast unused infrastructure. Now this resource is being recycled into a "green infrastructure" that is linking communities once again and creating sustainable economies. Through the efforts of local volunteers and state and federal funding, Pennsylvania leads the nation in the number of rail-trails, with 114 rail-trails totaling 929 miles.

The greatest growth in rail-trails has come as a result of Congress' creation of the Enhancement Program, administered through PennDOT. Most of the \$50 million-plus that has been spent on rail-trail development has come as a result of this program. Now, with the passage of Governor Ridge's \$565 million *Growing Greener* initiative, DEP and DCNR will be able to expand their programs and move toward the next frontier of greenway development: multi-objective greenways, with a heavy emphasis on water quality protection.

In addition to funding, more assistance is on the way. RTC has brought online the Trails and Greenways Clearinghouse and the Transportation Enhancements Clearinghouse. To aid in the development of trails in Pennsylvania, Governor Ridge has created, by executive order, the Pennsylvania Greenway Partnership Commission. The Commission has set out on a five-year course to provide a vision, structure, and more resources to expand the Commonwealth's greenway infrastructure to create a system of interconnected corridors.

While northeast Pennsylvania is quickly emerging as a rail-trail leader, Monroe County is ideally situated to connect with rail-trail networks under development in this region and create its own network with linkages to the vast acreage of open space still present in the County.

Railroad corridors in Monroe County with pertinence to the open space plan include the following:

- Monroe County presently has one rail-trail listed in the *Pennsylvania Rail-Trails* Directory. The "Old Railroad Trail" uses the Wilkes-

Barre and Eastern (WB&E) corridor and traverses Big Pocono State Park, Camelback Mountain Ski Resort, and ends at I-80, traversing a total of four miles. The entire WB&E corridor is abandoned and stretches from Stroudsburg to Wilkes-Barre. The corridor is predominately intact. Although much of the south segment property between Big Pocono east to Stroudsburg reverted to private ownership, much of the north segment is owned by public entities. Even if the entire line was not reconnected, the WB&E corridor offers good potential for the development of shorter trails. Certain on-road linkages could also be explored to create desired connections.

- The abandoned lines of the Stroudsburg Traction Line, or the Water Gap Trolley right-of-way, and the New York Susquehanna and Western are both utilized in the greenway and rail-trail project under development as the County's demonstration project (*Greenway Project Feasibility Study*). The latter parallels the south side of the Brodhead Creek, while the former traverses Godfrey Ridge. The trail will connect the boroughs of Stroudsburg, East Stroudsburg, and Delaware Water Gap and the townships of Stroud and Smithfield. The plan includes a bicycle/pedestrian bridge across the Brodhead Creek between Stroudsburg and East Stroudsburg.

The remaining corridors, including the remainder of the WB&E, rest in various states of disconnect.

- The abandoned Delaware Valley corridor from Stroudsburg to Bushkill sees informal use as a bridlepath. Although much of the track for the ill-fated railroad was never laid, embankments and grading were completed along much of the corridor.
- The abandoned Chestnut Ridge Railroad (CHR) extends 10 miles from Palmerton to Kunkletown. The eastern half of the corridor is used informally as a trail and is known as the Buckwha Creek Trail. The Wildlands Conservancy purchased an interest for the eastern segment. Ownership of this segment was recently obtained by and transferred to Eldred Township. Three miles of the western segment of the CHR continue to operate as an active railroad to serve Ampal, Inc. in Carbon County. A rail-with-trail scenario in this location would offer a proximate connection to the Delaware and Lehigh Canal National Heritage Corridor and State Heritage Park.
- The Lehigh & New England and the Lehigh & Lackawanna connect with Monroe County through Wind Gap and offer possible connections to Saylorsburg and Stroudsburg. Branches of these lines run west through Palmerton and south to Bath and beyond. These corridors, coupled with on-road bicycle/pedestrian facilities, could offer additional links within Monroe County and with adjacent counties.

- One active line bisects the County. The Delaware, Lackawanna and Western (DL&W) links Stroudsburg to Scranton via Cresco and Mount Pocono. Even though the Monroe County Rail Authority plans to implement high-speed rail service from Scranton to New York City, a rail-with-trail scenario may be possible. There are currently 64 such trails in the United States—nine of which are in Pennsylvania. However, the Monroe County Rail Authority does not currently favor a scenario such as this.

The following trail project priorities for these corridors are presented in order of importance given their potential impact and relative feasibility:

- Connect the Godfrey Ridge Trail (Brodhead Greenway) with the Paulinskill Valley Trail to create an interstate rail-trail and bicycling and hiking “gateway” to Pennsylvania. From Columbia, New Jersey, the trail would connect with the Columbia-Portland Footbridge (former covered bridge for automobiles) over the Delaware River. It would then run north on Route 611 and/or use remnants of railroad rights-of-way near the river to the borough of Delaware Water Gap and the new PennDOT visitors’ center. The active line (DL&W) utilizes the viaduct one mile north of Columbia to cross the Delaware River and so would be unavailable.
- Improve the WB&E corridor with a long-term goal of connecting Stroudsburg to Wilkes-Barre. Intermediate goals for the corridor should include purchasing and developing a trailhead at the Old Railroad Trail entrance off of Railroad Avenue located 1.5 miles from Interstate 80, Exit 45 (Route 715). Most of this several-mile trail is located in Big Pocono State Park and Camelback Ski Resort. The trail’s present right-of-way crosses the ski resort and should be relocated for safety reasons in order to link up with the remaining half of the trail to the northwest of the resort. In 1997, the Department of Conservation and Recreation’s Bureau of State Parks effectively closed the trail by removing it from state parks maps. However, meetings in the summer and fall of 2000 between the Rails-to-Trails Conservancy, DCNR, Camelback, and other local stakeholders have yielded general agreements for re-establishing the trail, provided other private landowners are willing.

Much of the WB&E corridor to the north of Interstate 80 is intact. Lackawanna and Luzerne Counties are especially interested in those segments owned by the State Forest Service, Game Commission, and PA Gas & Water. This corridor could provide local recreation opportunities for the Arrowhead Lake and Lake Naomi developments.

The majority of this abandoned right-of-way, which extends from Wilkes-Barre to Stroudsburg, is intact and holds great potential for a future trail. This railroad was abandoned in the 1930s and is segmented by Interstate Routes 80 and 380. The line’s ownership

has reverted to many different property owners. However, since many of these landowners are public entities, significant segments are still available. PG Energy, the Fish Commission, Game Commission and the Bureau of State Parks own significant segments. The Lackawanna River Corridor Association is currently under negotiations with some of these landowners in Lackawanna County. If these negotiations are successful, their success may give impetus for future planning in Monroe County. The abandoned line crosses into Monroe County from Clifton, Lackawanna County, and then runs through Pocono Lake, Pocono Summit, Tannersville, Readers, Bartonsville, and on to Stroudsburg. While the interstate routes did cut the line in half and the right-of-way has reverted to adjacent property owners, both obstacles can be overcome. One advantage is the fact that much of the line is now owned by public and private entities that are recreation-related or have been responsive to trail development efforts which would normally fall outside their corporation's main mission. For example, in the fall of 1999, PG Energy (formally Pennsylvania Gas and Water) donated their interest in 18.5 miles of an old rail line in Luzerne for the development of the Susquehanna Warrior Trail. Of course, the Game Commission and Bureau of State Parks have a few dozen operating rail-trails under their jurisdiction. Other excellent potential rail-trail owners and promoters for the WB&E are Big Pocono State Park, Camelback Ski Resort, and the Game Commission, since all these entities own or manage parts of the trail presently. At present, none of these entities have taken advantage of the opportunities the trail can offer. The Bureau has removed the trail from their public maps, while Camelback has posted their section of trail. The Game Commission clears foliage to maintain the right-of-way near Interstate 80. The rail-trail could be a tremendous asset to Camelback if it was developed in the context of a total hiking/bicycling system for the many recreational condominiums being constructed. To reconnect the WB&E north and south of Interstate 80, a bridge similar to the Appalachian Trail over Route 11 near Carlisle, or the Laurel Highlands Trail bridge over the Turnpike in Westmoreland County could be constructed. A parallel pathway could be built next to existing roads to cross over or under Route 380.

- Formally establish the NY Susquehanna & Western/ Delaware Valley corridor as a trail and connect it to the Brodhead Greenway. That portion of the one-mile NYS&W is currently utilized near Shawnee as a horse trail and should be expanded where feasible with priority given to connecting southward to the proposed Godfrey Ridge Trail.
- Encourage Northampton County to develop a linkage with Pen Argyl and the Plainfield Township Trail using the L&NE corridor from the Delaware River at Portland and consider the development of on-road facilities where appropriate to create a continuous corridor.

- Encourage linkage to the Delaware Water Gap Nation Recreation Area's trail system as put forth in the Final Trails Plan and abbreviated Environmental Impact Statement of November 1999.

Road Corridors

Opportunities for non-motorized transportation, recreation, scenic enjoyment, and historical interpretation are provided by many of the County's road corridors. These can also provide important linkages between other greenway resources. As a general rule in all county and municipal plans, consideration should be given to creating bicycle- and pedestrian-friendly communities. The references cited in Chapter 1 provide important guidance in this regard. Bicycle- and pedestrian-friendly roadway considerations can also contribute significantly to the greenway network as they can provide access through sensitive greenway corridors and make connections which may have been lost or are not currently feasible. In order to understand the current condition of local roadways and to assist greenway-planning, municipalities should assess the bicycle compatibility of all roadways within their jurisdiction by preparing bicycle compatibility studies to identify and assess potential bike routes, roadways needing improvement, and/or roadways where PennDOT "Share the Road" signs might best be placed.

Utility Corridors

Utility corridors include electric, cable, and gas lines in Monroe County. Often traversing steep terrain, hunters, hikers, and mountain bikers are attracted to these corridors. Utility corridors can also be actively managed for wildlife. The County should initiate communication with the owners of these utility corridors for multiple use potential as recreation and greenway corridors.

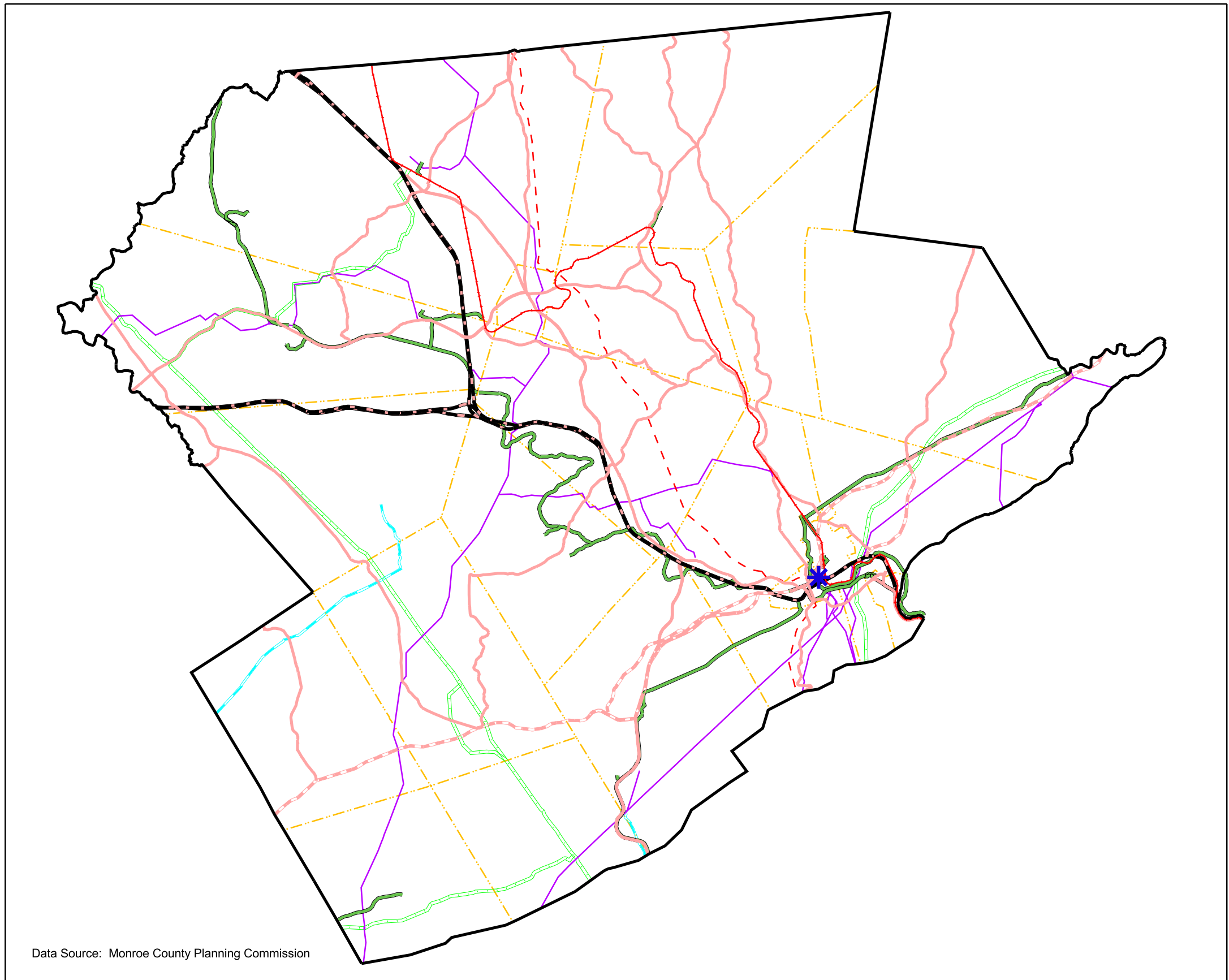
Levee System

The levee system, built for flood control by the Army Corp of Engineers along the Brodhead Creek between the boroughs of Stroudsburg and East Stroudsburg, offers opportunities for multiple use as a greenway with trails. This system occurs along the Brodhead Creek between the boroughs of Stroudsburg and East Stroudsburg and Stroud Township. It should be an integral component to the development of a greenway with a trails system along this segment.

Historic Trails

Monroe County's Historic Legacy Report describes many of these early trails and pathways. While their locations may often intersect with modern roadways, they offer a unique opportunity to interpret the County's history, offer recreation opportunities, and may also serve as tourist attractions. These resources should be mapped and incorporated into the municipal-level plans. They might also be added to the municipal maps of local green infrastructure as secondary potential conservation areas.

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Data Source: Monroe County Planning Commission



County Open Space Plan
Monroe County, Pennsylvania

Map Legend

- Abandon Rail Corridors
- Active Rail Corridor
- Major Roads**
 - Interstate Road
 - U.S. Traffic Routes
 - PA. Traffic Routes
- Major Utility Corridors**
 - Electric
 - Natural Gas
 - Telephone
 - Water
- Levee System
- Municipal Boundaries

**Man-Made
Linear Corridors**

Figure - 7.7



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Step 2 - Inventory existing regional and inter-municipal greenways

Existing regional and inter-municipal greenways in the County are few. The *Appalachian Trail*, which runs along the ridgeline forming Monroe County's southeastern border, is one of the nation's premiere greenways as noted above. The *Old Railroad Trail* is a four-mile rail-trail in the vicinity of Big Pocono State Park that runs atop the abandoned WB&E corridor (see *Figure 7.7*). While it is listed in the directory put out by the Pennsylvania Chapter of the Rails-to-Trails Conservancy, it was taken off the DCNR maps due to access problems as noted above.

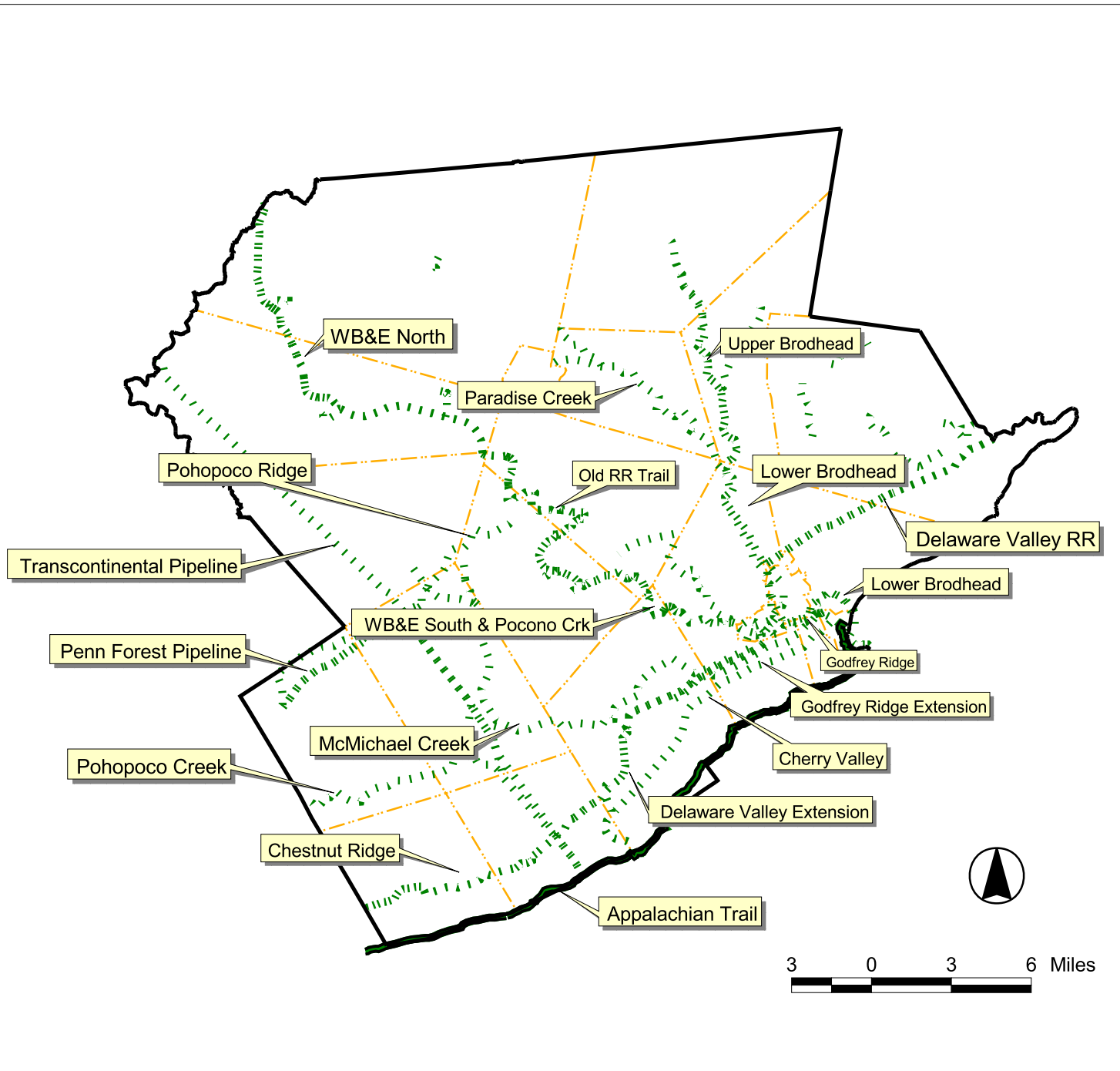
Conceptual greenway plans have been prepared for the Flagler Run Greenway and Brodhead Greenway in Stroud Township. And, other municipalities are beginning to recognize greenways and trails in their planning documents.

With the many resources outlined above to build upon, Monroe County need only recognize what it has in order to take advantage of the current funding programs and opportunities which encourage the identification and implementation of greenways and trails in the County. During public involvement sessions conducted as part of this project, the preceding *Greenway Project Feasibility Study*, and during the Monroe 2020 planning process, Monroe County citizens have identified several potential greenway corridors. These are primarily on existing linear corridors that experience some use as trails by county residents, however they are not formally established as greenways with trails and current usage could be curtailed or limited as the county grows. *Figure 7.8 – Potential Greenway Corridors* illustrates the location of these potential greenway corridors identified during the public involvement process. These corridors are however fairly evenly distributed throughout the County and may offer spines from which many other greenway connections could be realized. Also, to compliment the development of Greenways in the County, state and local roadways in each municipality should be assessed for bicycle and pedestrian compatibility consistent with the *Statewide Bicycle & Pedestrian Master Plan* prepared for the Commonwealth of Pennsylvania Department of Transportation.

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County Open Space Plan

Monroe County, Pennsylvania



Map Legend

- Potential Greenways
- Existing Greenways
- Municipal Boundary

Potential Greenways Identified through the public involvement process. These corridors currently experience some usage by county residents.

Potential Greenway Corridors

Figure 7.8

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Demonstration/ Model Greenway & Trail System

An inter-municipal greenway vision has been developed for the Brodhead Greenway through the public involvement effort conducted as part of the County's Greenway Feasibility Study for a portion of that greater vision (the Godfrey Ridge section of the Brodhead Greenway). The greenway offers a unique combination of opportunities. Its location in the heart of the traditional cross-roads of the County make it an important component of a major hub for the county greenway system and a vital link for realizing the greater vision for the Brodhead Greenway. Other opportunities and functions that can be served and realized through its development include:

- Linkage to other communities (five municipalities);
- Recreation – provides walking, biking, cross-county skiing, fishing, equestrian trails, and links to recreation resources;
- Preserves an existing network of trails;
- Provides potential linkage to trails of regional significance;
- Alternative transportation – non-motorized trails connecting people to community resources;
- Conservation – provides wildlife corridor protection and protects fragile ecosystems;
- Educational and interpretive opportunities – nature study, historic trolley line, etc.;
- Water quality – provides riparian buffers for streams, floodplain protection, and flood and erosion control;
- Scenic quality – protection of a major viewshed at the gateway to the County; and
- Tourism/ Economic Opportunities – provides financial and economic benefits to communities.

These assets offer a set of evaluation criteria by which other potential corridors can be rated. Additional criteria may be added through further public involvement.

As its first priority, the County should focus on the Godfrey Ridge Greenway and trail as a model or demonstration greenway in the County's most urbanized core area and in an area that has served as a cross-roads since humans first inhabited this region of the country. This project is described with specific actions to be taken in the *Monroe Greenway Project Feasibility Study*. Done well, it can encourage and foster the development of other major greenway spines in the County. It can serve to illustrate all six phases of the creation of a greenway or trail as outlined in the Pennsylvania Greenways Partnership's manual, *Creating Connections*:

1. Visioning;
2. Building support;
3. Planning the project;
4. Acquisition;
5. Development; and
6. Managing.

Appendix A of this plan provides the executive summary from the *Greenway Feasibility Project Study*.

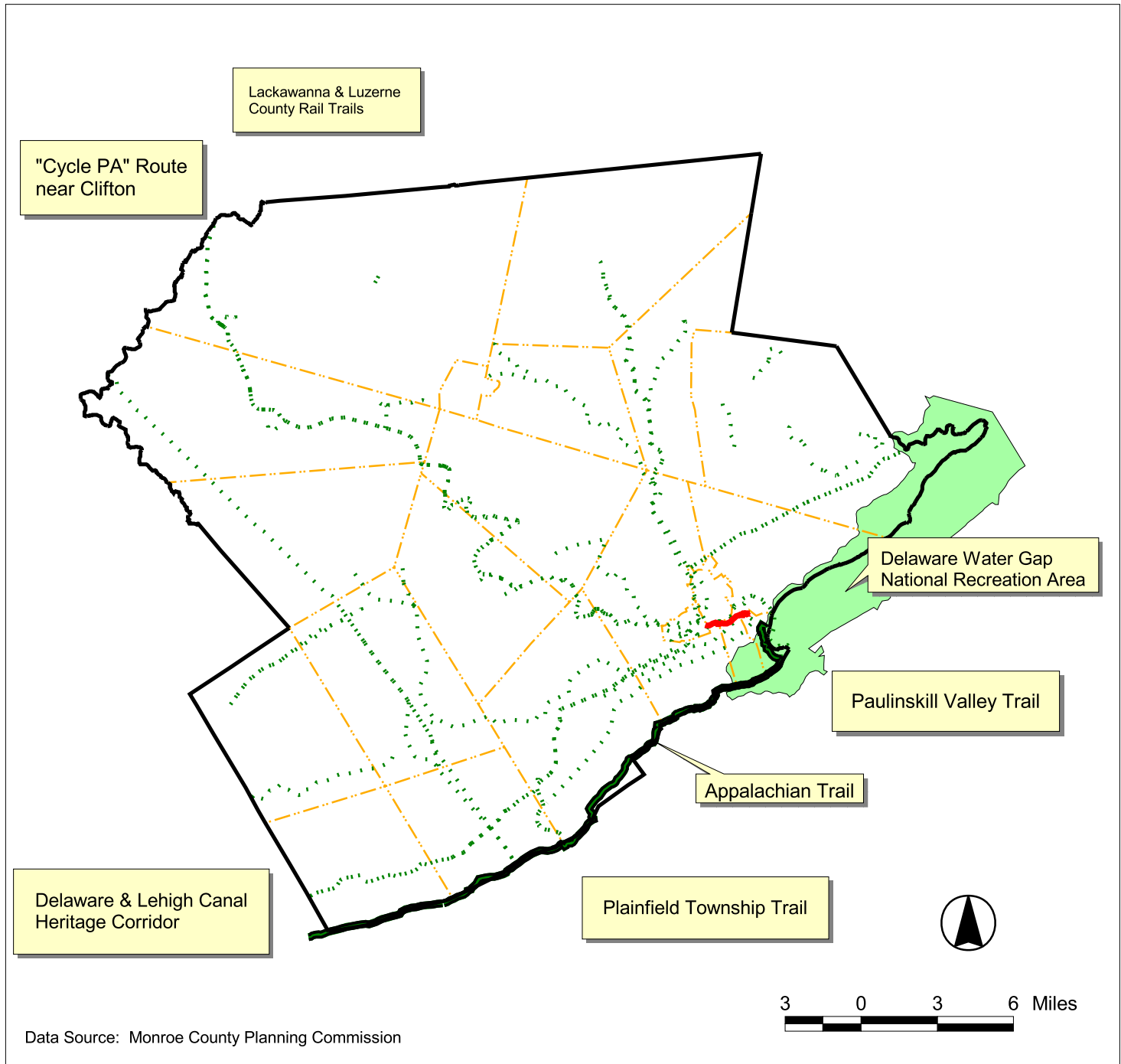
Regional Greenways & Trails

Several important regional greenways and trails are located in adjacent counties and states. Adjacent counties in both Pennsylvania and New Jersey possess both active rail-trails and greenway projects noteworthy as possible linkages to future trails in Monroe County.

- To the east, the Paulinskill Valley Trail, a New Jersey State Park, stretches 27.3 miles from Sparta Junction to Columbia and runs very near the Monroe County border and future rail-trail development;
- The 6.7-mile Plainfield Township Trail in Northampton County connects Stockerton to Pen Argyl;
- To the south, the Appalachian Trail (AT) follows the Monroe-Northampton County line, winds through the Delaware Water Gap, and continues north through Delaware Water Gap National Recreation Area;
- To the west, the Delaware and Lehigh Heritage Corridor connects to Jim Thorpe northward through White Haven and Wilkes-Barre, and then will soon connect to another quickly emerging rail-trail system that links to Scranton and on to the New York border;
- To the north a series of rail trails are being developed in Lackawanna and Luzerne counties. Also a “Cycle PA” north-south statewide bicycle route passes close to the County near Clifton just outside the County line and very near to the abandoned rail corridor of the WB&E.

County Open Space Plan

Monroe County, Pennsylvania



Map Legend

- | | | | |
|--|---------------------|--|----------------------|
| | Existing Greenways | | Potential Greenways |
| | Godfrey Ridge Trail | | Municipal Boundaries |

Potential Regional Links

Figure 7.9

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Step 3 – Identify Potential Conceptual Greenway Priority Corridors based on factors examined in steps 1 and 2

Several factors come into play in terms of how the County should best support and encourage the development of a countywide greenway system. First and foremost, the County should advance the demonstration greenway as put forth in the *Greenway Project Feasibility Study* as its top priority. The initial development effort called for in this report is for an approximate three-mile section of trail called the “Godfrey Ridge Trail”. This project area is in the most urbanizing section of the county and in an area that has the greatest concentration of the County’s population. It is also located at a vital crossroads to the entire conceptual greenway system as proposed herein. The County also needs to demonstrate success and positive results, as greenway development in the County is a relatively new endeavor. The focus on a demonstration greenway that has high visibility and its successful development as part of an larger conceptual system is therefore a critical first step to the realization of the whole system.

Second, in order to grow the greenway as a system and engage partners, the County should encourage and support incubator projects within the entire conceptual greenway system. These projects, identified and put forth by municipal, joint municipal, or non-profit groups, will inherently have the level of support needed to take their identified segment(s) to the next level of planning and will epitomize the development of that portion of a conceptual greenway segment most appropriate to develop first. The County should support and partner with individual stakeholder groups in a way that best supports those individual efforts. Apart from the recognition of the importance of incubator project with strong local support, several other factors were recognized as important from the county perspective that should be taken into consideration when supporting these incubator projects. These factors include the following:

- Potential to preserve riparian stream buffers;
- Threat of loss of the resource or corridor posed by development pressure; and
- Distribution throughout the County.

The following corridors were identified based on findings in steps 1 and 2 and are presented in an approximate order of importance given their potential attractiveness for development. Initial efforts should focus on greenway acquisitions along stream corridors in segments most threatened by development pressures. This approach has the advantage of protecting the resource and the overall integrity of the countywide system and buys time to develop plans for development efforts, which would include efforts to congeal management and operation plans among the many potential partners that can eventually realize the countywide system.

Nine major conceptual spines as illustrated in *Figure 7.10 –Priority Conceptual Greenways* were identified which are distributed throughout the County from its central hub and the County seat where the County’s densest population now resides.

The County's GIS data sets were used to assist in the evaluation of the factors influencing the creation of greenways and their description. Further planning studies need to be made in order to identify specific segments and opportunities within the following conceptual spines:

1. Brodhead Creek Corridor
2. Pocono Creek Corridor and WB&E Rail Corridor
3. McMichael Creek Corridor
4. Popocho/Weir Creek Corridor
5. Paradise Creek Corridor
6. Cherry Valley - Godfrey Ridge Corridor
7. Delaware Valley Rail Corridor
8. Chestnut Ridge Corridor
9. Pohopoco Ridge Corridor

These spines generally follow major stream corridors, ridgelines, or abandoned rail corridors. Potential linkage to greenway corridors outside the county as discussed above should also be an important focus for the County. The County should initiate efforts to help realize these potentialities. Descriptions of the nine major conceptual corridors follow:

Brodhead Creek Corridor – This conceptual greenway runs from the confluence of the Brodhead Creek with the Delaware River near the community of Delaware Water Gap to the communities of Canadensis, Mountainhome, and Buck Hill Falls for a distance of approximately eighteen (18) miles. The corridor may be logically divided into the upper and lower reaches. It is the lower reach, from the community of Analomink south to Delaware Water Gap that was “visioned” during the *Monroe Greenway Project Feasibility Study* and of which the proposed Godfrey Ridge Greenway is a segment.

Pocono Creek Corridor – This corridor runs in close proximity to the southeastern reaches of the WB&E abandoned rail corridor, diverting off this course near the community of Bartonsville where it heads north to Tannersville, then west up the Pocono Plateau escarpment into headwater reaches and State Game Lands No. 38. The distance of the corridor is approximately thirteen (13) miles. The Pocono Creek meets the McMichael Creek in the borough of Stroudsburg. This corridor also provides a cross-linkage opportunity from the Brodhead watershed to the Tobyhanna and Tunkhannock Creek watershed. Scenic roadways also parallel this upper section of the corridor and may offer additional access opportunities and should be preserved and enhanced in their own right (note also that the absence of street lighting in this section provides optimal views of the night sky).

McMichael Creek Corridor – This conceptual greenway runs from its confluence with the Brodhead Creek in the borough of Stroudsburg southwesterly through

Stroud Township and past the Glen Brook County Club into a Hemlock Ravine through a tract recently purchased by Stroud Township as a municipal park. It then jogs northwesterly, then southwesterly, near the community of Snydersville in Hamilton Township and past the County-owned lands where the Monroe County Recreation and Park Commission has its headquarters. It continues southwesterly to the historic village of Sciota. It then courses westerly into Chestnuthill Township to a 114-acre tract of land near Lake Mineola. This tract was recently acquired by the Nature Conservancy and will eventually be held by the Pocono Heritage Land Trust. 25 percent of the tract area will serve an active recreation purpose including several ball fields for league play. There are also large tracts of land along this stretch of the corridor, which are owned by the Pohoqualine Fish Association. The creek then turns north toward Chestnut Hill's municipal park and finally turns northwesterly through Hipsy Gap that defines the climb up the Pocono Plateau escarpment into its headwaters located in State Game Lands No. 38. The total length is approximately twenty-one (21) miles.

Pohopoco / Weir Creek Corridor – This conceptual greenway starts near the Pleasant Valley High School in Brodheadsville and travels southwesterly along Weir Creek and Pohopoco Creek to the village of Kresgeville for a total approximate distance of eight miles if followed to the point where the Pohopoco Creek meets the county line.

Paradise Creek Corridor – This conceptual greenway starts at the confluence of Paradise Creek with the Brodhead Creek near the intersection of Routes 191 and 447. This corridor provides a link between the village of Analomink and the borough of Mount Pocono. The stream corridor is primarily undeveloped. The stream itself is a very high quality stream and viable native fishery as many recent studies have documented. Much of the mainstem riparian stream corridor is already in a state of protection through efforts of various fishing clubs and larger land holdings. The headwater area is less protected and currently under significant development pressure as the Mount Pocono area continues to be the focus of urban growth. The roadway corridor, which parallels the stream corridor, is also one of the most scenic in the County and offers potential for bicycle- and pedestrian-compatible facilities as well as being a designated scenic and historic drive.

Cherry Valley–Godfrey Ridge Corridor – This conceptual greenway corridor follows two parallel linear features, as its name implies. The ridge intersects with the proposed Godfrey Ridge Trail as described in the *Monroe Greenway Feasibility Project Study* near its serpentine descent into the Borough of Delaware Water Gap. Cherry Creek meets the Delaware River just north of the historic Delaware Water Gap Train Station. From these points, the corridor runs southeasterly through Cherry Valley, the smallest discrete watershed in the County. Cherry Valley is a limestone valley with a unique ecosystem, highly acclaimed for its visual quality. The other parallel ridge forming this valley is the Kittatinny Mountain with the Appalachian Trail traversing its top. The county roads that travel through this valley are a favorite with long-distance bicyclists. From Delaware Water Gap, approximately 3.5 miles of Route 191 bisects the valley, connecting Stroudsburg with Bangor in Northampton County. Traveling another 2.5 miles through the valley, there is the small hamlet of Stormsville, a farming community that once boasted a stagecoach stop, a farrier, a saddlemaker, a general store, a butcher shop, and a grange hall. The ridge through this section contains the Stroudsmoor Country Inn, Hartman's Cave, and the Living Historic Farm of "Quiet Valley." The ridge has historically provided a pathway for

hikers, equestrians, and more recently, mountain bikers. Another 2.0 miles away is the hamlet of Bossardsville, a crossroads where one can head west to the small community of Hamilton Square and Sciota Village. The ridge ends near Hamilton Square. Traveling southwesterly for another 3.5 miles, the valley ends near the Cherry Valley Vineyards and is bisected by the limited access highway Route 33. The valley still contains many small farms throughout its length. Total approximate length is eight (8) miles.

Delaware Valley Rail Corridor – The Delaware Valley Rail Corridor is divided into two major sections. The section northeast of the Brodhead Creek was an active rail line between 1901 and 1938. A portion of the former rail-bed serves a power line easement today and passes through the Delaware Water Gap National Recreation Area. It also roughly parallels Route 209 with portions of the roadway overlaying the former rail bed. The second section southwest of the Brodhead Creek was a planned extension of the railroad that was never fully constructed and tracks were never laid. However, embankments and grading are still visible along this route. This corridor parallels the McMichael Creek corridor in its eastern reach. The two corridors may provide alternative options for the development of one joint corridor in this reach. The remaining reach passes through relatively rolling and open countryside through Cherry Valley linking to the Saylorsburg area and then head toward the Wind Gap area.

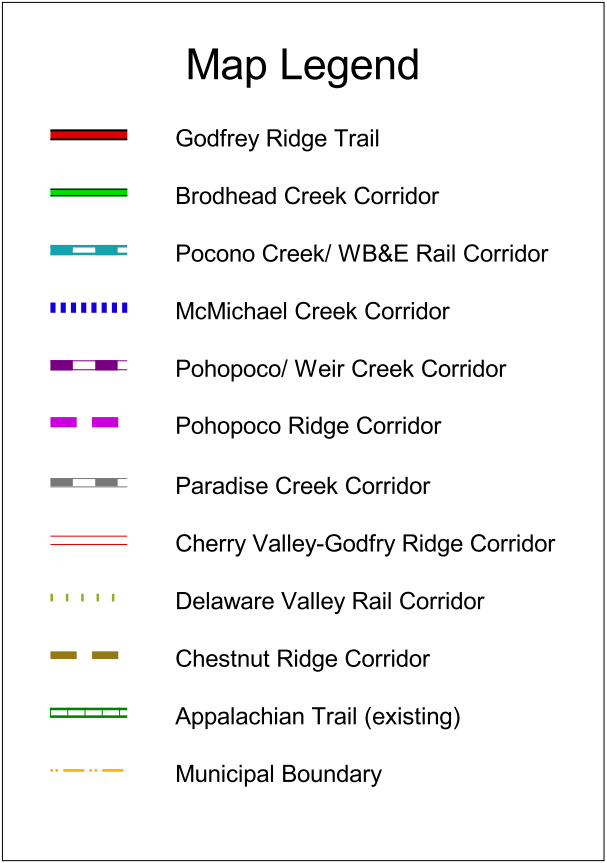
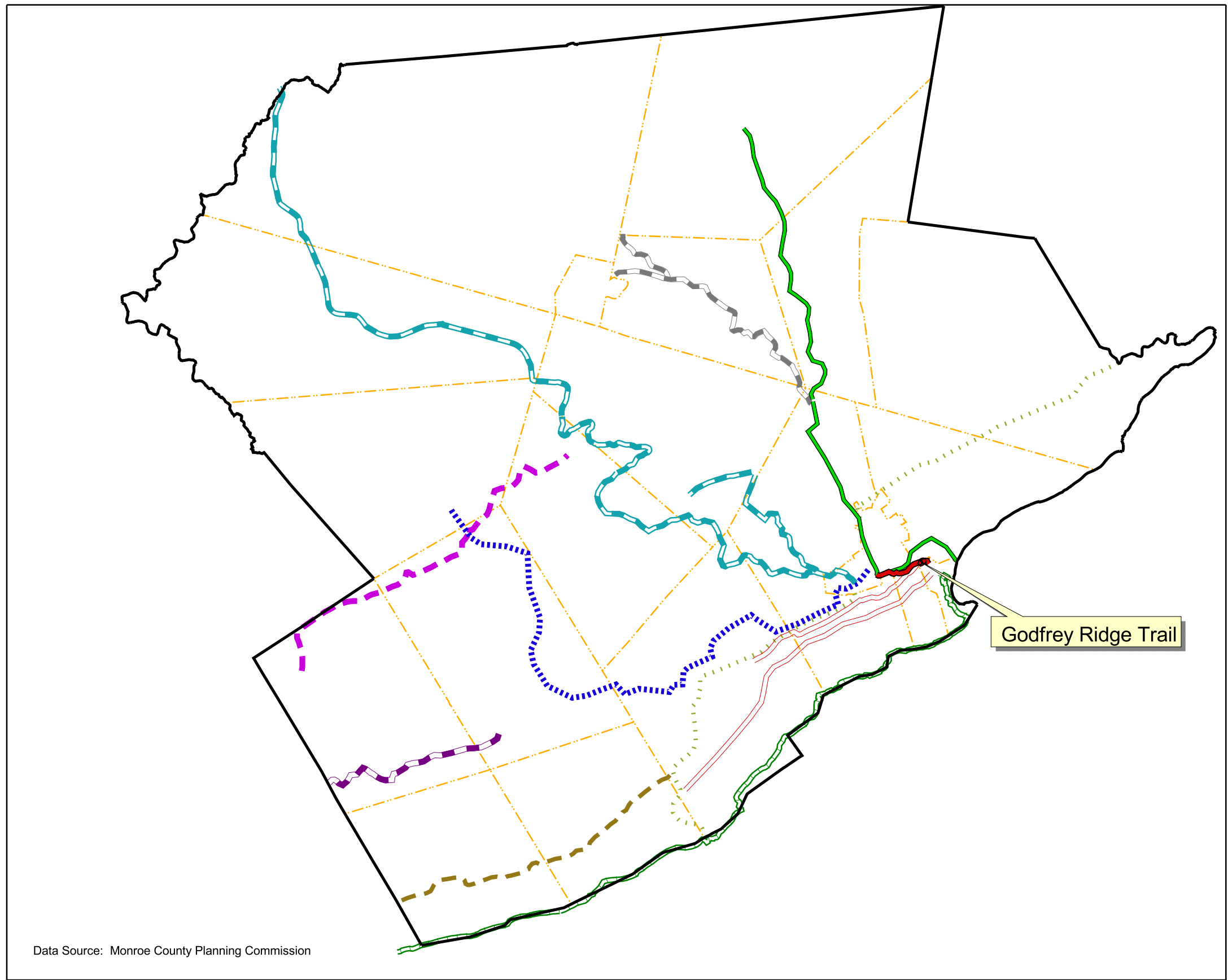
Chestnut Ridge Corridor – Southwest of Cherry Valley and Route 33, near the village of Saylorsburg in Ross Township, the Chestnut Ridge begins. This corridor also parallels Kittatinny Mountain and the Appalachian Trail, approximately a mile and a half southeast. Northwest of Chestnut Ridge is the Buckwha Creek. Traveling approximately 4 miles along this ridge in a southwesterly direction, one enters Eldred Township. Traveling another 4 miles in this direction you come upon the village of Kunkletown. This area is rich in Native American history as it was near the site of a major village. To the south along this distance, the Aquashicola Creek has its start, and Smith Gap descends into Kunkletown. Kunkletown was also the terminus of the Chestnut Ridge Rail Line, which runs close to the Buckwha Creek in this area. This abandoned right-of-way was recently acquired by Eldred Township for a recreational trail. It was purchased from the Wildlands Conservancy, who first recognized its importance. The Chestnut Ridge Line connects with the borough of Palmerton in Northampton County and is a potential link to the Delaware and Lehigh Canal Heritage Corridor. The Blue Mountain Ski Area is a few miles further down on the Chestnut Ridge in Northampton County. Total approximate distance in Monroe County is eight (8) miles.

Pohopoco Ridge Corridor – This corridor runs along the escarpment of the Pocono Plateau from a western origin within the Penn Forest Reservoir (an NAI site), connecting to State Gamelands No. 38 and Bethlehem Water Authority lands in the vicinity of Hypsy Gap, the headwaters of the McMichael Creek Corridor. It then continues along the top of the escarpment, ultimately connecting to trailheads in Big Pocono State Park. In its western reach, this corridor also offers a regional connection that could continue along the ridge into Carbon County and beyond. This is an important scenic and wildlife corridor and parallels the transition zone between two physiographic provinces, the Pocono Plateau Section of the Appalachian Plateaus Province and the Ridge and Valley Province.

Greenway Composite

A composite map illustrating the “fit” of the priority conceptual greenways with the potential greenway hubs and nodes is illustrated by *Figure 7.11 – Composite Greenway System*.

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The "Godfrey Ridge Trail" is a proposed trail and greenway development effort that provides a segment of the Brodhead Creek corridor and provides potential linkage to the Cherry Valley/ Godfrey Ridge corridor, the Mc Michael Creek corridor, the Delaware Valley corridor, and the Pocono Creek/ WB&E corridor.



County Open Space Plan

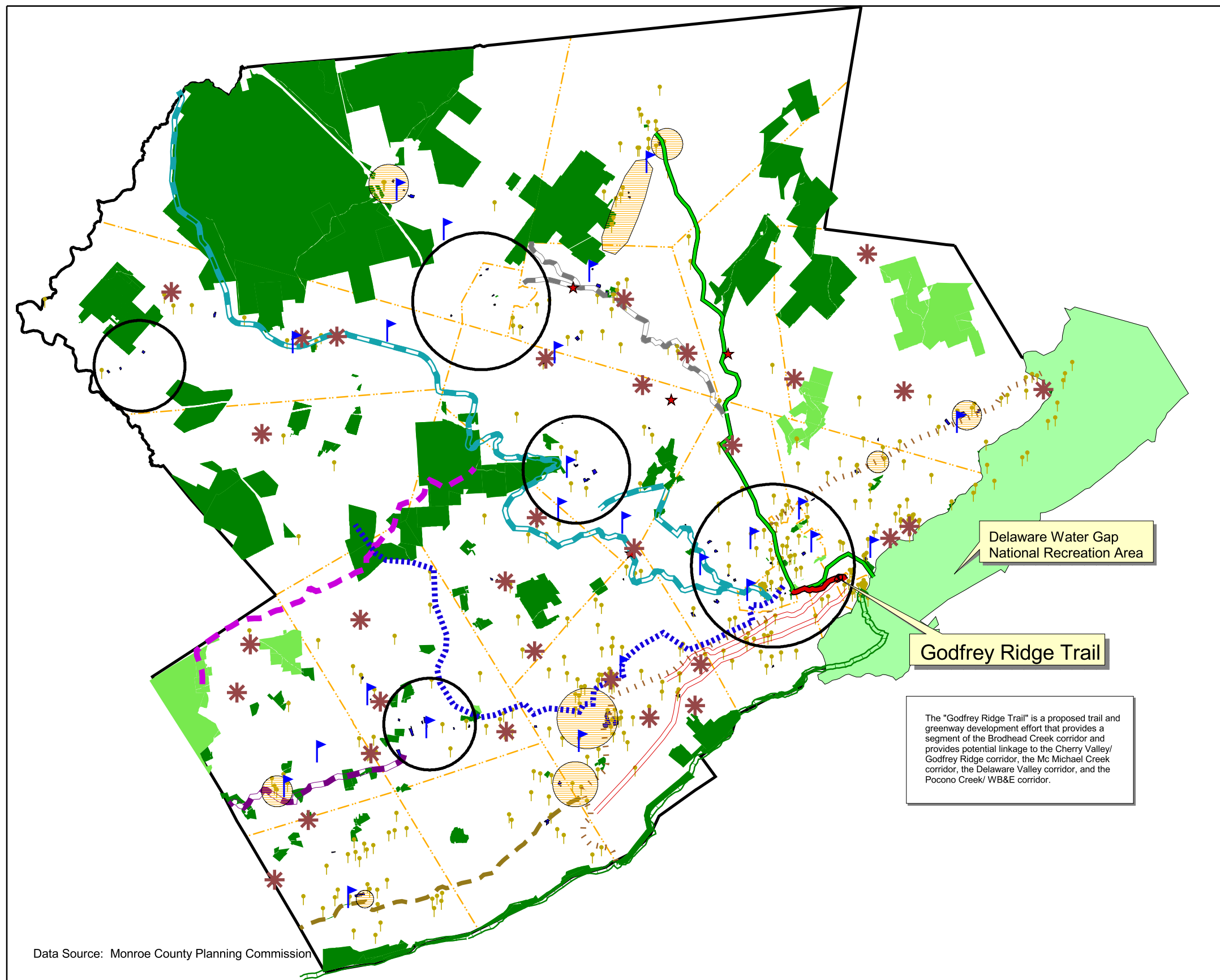
Monroe County, Pennsylvania

Priority Conceptual Greenways

Figure - 7.10



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Priority Conceptual Greenways

- Godfrey Ridge Trail
- Brodhead Creek Corridor
- Pocono Creek/ WB&E Corridor
- - - McMichael Creek Corridor
- - - Pohopoco/ Weir Creek Corridor
- - - Paradise Creek Corridor
- - - Cherry Valley-Godfrey Ridge Corridor
- - - Delaware Valley Corridor
- - - Chestnut Ridge Corridor
- - - Pohopoco Ridge Corridor
- - - Appalachian Trail (existing)
- - - Municipal Boundary

Potential Hubs & Nodes

- ▲ Schools
- Libraries & Churches
- Urbanizing Centers
- Villages
- ✱ Hamlets
- ⬮ Historic Site/Structure
- ★ Covered Bridge Site
- Protected Lands
- Quasi Public Lands

Composite Potential Greenway System

Figure - 7.11



County Open Space Plan

Monroe County, Pennsylvania

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Conclusions

The County should take a leadership role in establishing an interconnected greenway system throughout the County and one that can connect to adjacent counties. This will provide a strong network for the creation of the green infrastructure referred to in the County's Comprehensive Plan.

Recommendations

1. As its first priority, the County should focus on the development of the Godfrey Ridge Trail of the Brodhead Greenway as a model or demonstration greenway in the County's most urbanized core area. The County needs to create a model for success by implementing recommendations contained in that report. It should also be a priority to advance the greenway system out from this central core in all directions.
2. The municipalities should utilize the resources referenced in this chapter and the overall conceptual framework for the development and advancement of greenways in their immediate region.
3. The County should take the lead in establishing a formal coordinating mechanism with the principals/owners of the large tracts of federal and state lands. Quarterly meetings among principals to review open space policy and operations should be established and promoted. A similar mechanism should also be established with the principals/owners of large tracts of privately held lands.
4. The County should lead in the procuring of additional greenway feasibility studies through the major corridors identified in this report. Those most threatened by development pressure should be pursued first, but all should be done as soon as possible.
5. The County should work with municipalities to help them build the potential countywide system (one development at a time) in ways that provide both short-term and long-term assistance that ensure that opportunities are not lost through actions which may be slowed due to the development process.
6. The County should encourage and support municipal and private partners in the planning and development of incubator projects that develop greenway segments along the priority conceptual greenway corridors.
7. In order to understand the current condition of local roadways and to assist greenway planning, the county should assist the municipalities by assessing the bicycle compatibility of all roadways within their jurisdiction through the preparation of bicycle compatibility studies of roadways within their jurisdiction. These studies should be prepared by professionals with expertise in making these assessments and should be consistent with statewide bicycle and pedestrian master plan.

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